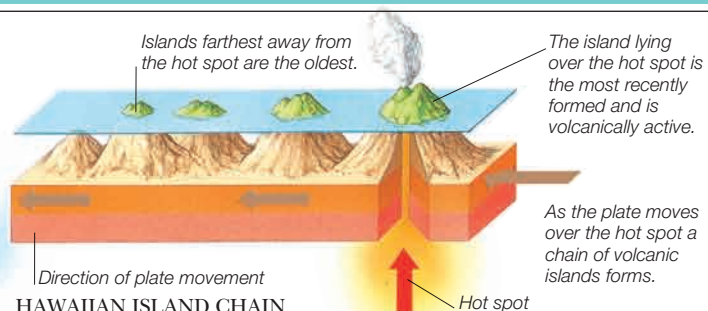
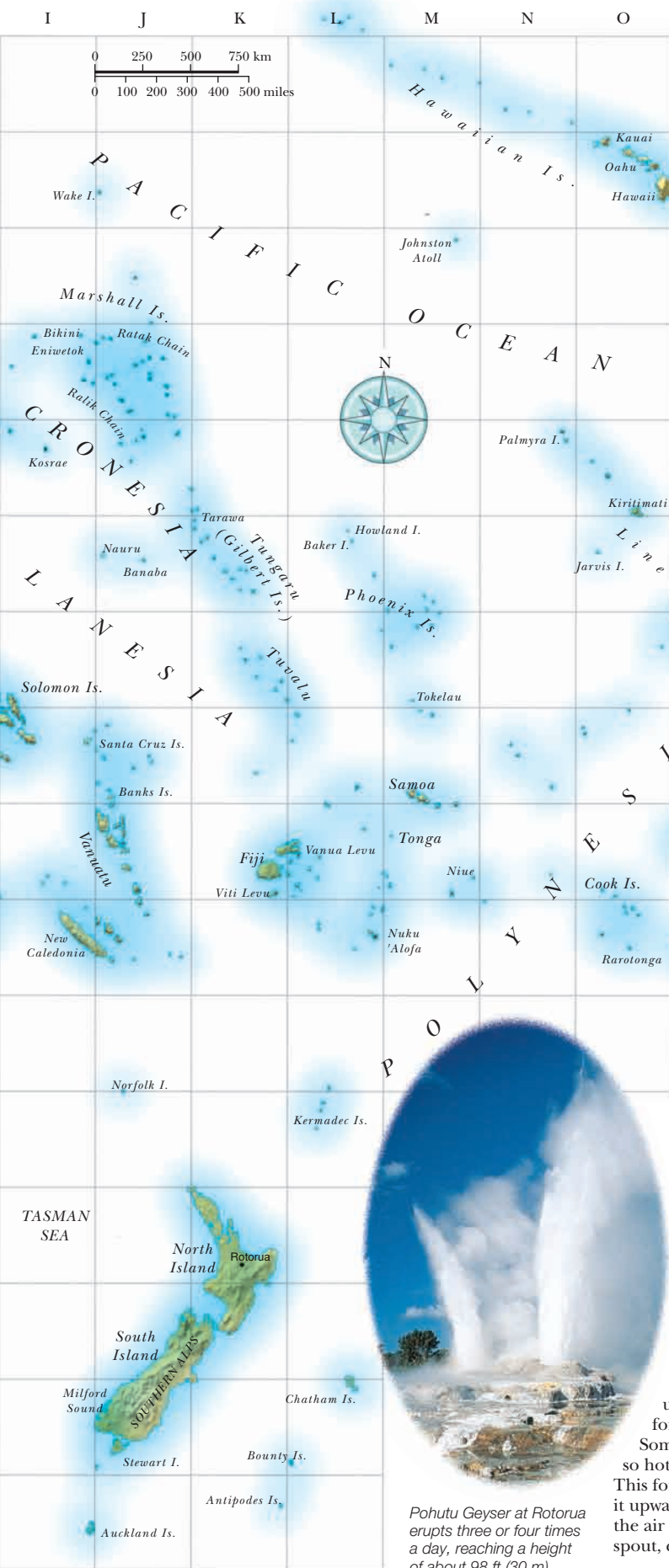


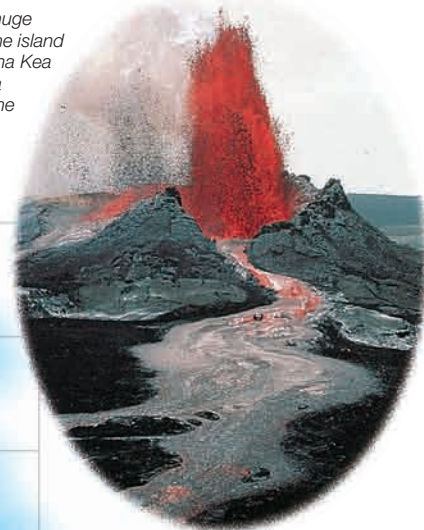


HAWAIIAN ISLAND CHAIN

Some Pacific islands are steep-sided volcanoes, rising out of the sea. The Hawaiian Islands are a chain of 132 islands that were formed by "hot spot" volcanoes. Most volcanoes occur along the edges of the plates that make up the Earth's crust. But hot spot volcanoes are found over isolated plumes of magma (red-hot liquid rock) rising up through the seafloor. As the plates of crust move across a hot spot, a new volcano is born. At present, the hot spot lies under the island of Hawaii itself.

P

There are two huge volcanoes on the island of Hawaii: Mauna Kea and Mauna Loa (shown here), the world's largest active volcano.



S T

The Barrier Reef was formed by tiny creatures, called corals.



GEYSERS

New Zealand's North Island is part of the Pacific "Ring of Fire" and has hundreds of active volcanoes which are erupting all the time. The hot, volcanic rocks heat underground water, which bubbles up through cracks to form boiling hot springs. Sometimes the water gets so hot it turns to steam. This forces the water above it upward, until it bursts into the air in a tall, spectacular spout, called a geyser.



Pohutu Geyser at Rotorua erupts three or four times a day, reaching a height of about 98 ft (30 m).

THE GREAT BARRIER REEF

The world's largest coral reef lies off the northeastern coast of Australia. The Great Barrier Reef is a chain of more than 2,500 smaller reefs. Most of the reef was formed in the last 2 million years, but parts are 25 million years old. There are now fears that human activities, such as tourism and mining, are damaging the fragile balance of the reef and its wildlife.